attempts to extort money from it. Its hands were clean, and it had nothing to hide: its officials had only met with ULFA under the ‘guidance and counsel’ of the ‘authorities’. It further added that it had resisted the choice to ‘pull out of Assam’ and instead sought to deal with the ‘unusual situation’ by intensifying its social welfare schemes to ‘demonstrate the Company’s goodwill towards the people of the state’. The schemes implemented by the group were also enumerated. It emphasized how the Tatas had focused on providing much-needed succour to the needy in Assam and maintained that it should not be faulted for ‘an aberration in the implementation of the scheme at the local level’. The press release emphasized that Tata Tea would review the process of the medical programme and ‘if such misuse cannot be eliminated, even discontinue the scheme entirely’.

The drafting of the release by the Tata bureaucracy was, however, sloppy. Inadvertently, it injected an inappropriate underpinning. The release said that the group was undertaking the welfare schemes ‘in the hope that its personnel would be spared intimidation’.

Ratan now says that the group had never paid the militants but all its efforts at impressing upon the government of this fact bore little result. He is easily disturbed when his actions are misread. He wants people to believe in his actions. And if they do not, as a last resort, he would prefer to give up what he does to put an end to misinterpretations.

In Assam too, he wanted the people to believe that the Tatas had done nothing wrong but unfortunately its welfare scheme was misused. The group should not be blamed for anyone taking advantage of the medical scheme, he bemoaned.

Soon after the DGP’s press conference, Ratan flew to Delhi and persuaded Union Home Secretary K. Padmanabhaiah to talk to the DGP and get him to appreciate the group’s version. Ratan also took it upon himself to personally apprise the home minister and chief minister of Assam that Tata Tea had not supported militancy in any form and the assistance rendered in Deka’s case was unintentional. West Bengal Chief Minister Jyoti Basu also intervened on his behalf and requested his Assam counterpart to meet Ratan.

Ratan wrote to Mahanta on 12 September, seeking an appointment. He wrote that the meeting would help ensure that Mahanta was ‘satisfied about the bona fides of Tata Tea, which has sincerely and genuinely endeavoured to serve the best interests of the people of Assam through its community